held lands towards the Christian kingdom of Armenia, where the men could gather themselves for the assault on Saladin.

They arrived at the Armenian border in June of 1190. Hearing that the king of Armenia himself had come to greet him and was waiting on the other side of the shallow Saleph river, Frederick Barbarossa began to ford the river on horseback. Somehow, he fell; and in waist-deep water, surrounded by his own men, the emperor drowned.[9]

Without their leader, the German army divided. Some of the men headed back home to swear loyalty to the new emperor, Henry VI. Others pushed on, but plague and heat began to diminish their number. “Disease and death fell upon them,” writes the Arab chronicler Ibn al-Athir, “and they reached Antioch, looking as though they had been exhumed from their graves.” The king of Antioch, Bohemund III, was not particularly pleased to see them: “He encouraged them to join the Franks at Acre,” Ibn al-Athir says, “. . . but mortality was high among them, and only about a thousand of them were left.”[10]

The few who straggled on found the former King Guy of Jerusalem camped outside Acre’s walls. Guy had been freed by Saladin the previous winter after taking an oath not to fight against the Muslims, which he promptly broke by laying siege to Saladin’s stronghold at Acre. The siege had begun in August of 1189, and the pathetic German reinforcements did nothing to tip the balance towards the besiegers; Acre was *still* under siege when Philip II of France finally arrived, in April of 1191. “Considering how many noblemen have been at this siege,” Philip is said to have remarked, “it is extraordinary how slow they have been to take it.” But the Frankish reinforcements—six ships, rather than the huge numbers of men Guy had hoped for—also proved inadequate to bring Acre down.[11]